Flourish
LEGAL WELL-BEING

Understanding Your Use of Substances (and Changing It, If You Want)

The *harm reduction framework* offers a nonjudgmental approach to understanding your relationship with substances. It supports exploring changes without rigid "all-or-nothing" thinking.

Start with Curiosity

- Notice when, where, and with whom you use substances.
- Identify any emotional states that lead to or follow use, like stress after work or social anxiety at events.
- Look for automatic patterns. *E.g.*, do you tend to order a drink without thinking?

Assess the Upsides and Downsides

- Identify any benefits: do substances help you relax, socialize, or unwind?
- Weigh any negatives: are there impacts on your work, health, relationships, or mood?

Set Realistic, Personalized Goals

- Goals can be flexible, *e.g.*, reducing frequency, moderating quantity, or making specific changes in certain situations.
- You might choose abstinence for some substances but moderation for others.
- Aim for small, manageable steps to build momentum. Consider focusing on one goal at a time.

Warning Signs to Notice

- Using more than planned
- Cravings
- Unsuccessful attempts to cut back
- Usage affecting your work, relationships, or mental or physical health
- Note: Experiencing tolerance (needing more for the same effect) or withdrawal symptoms suggests a stronger dependency.

When to Seek Help

- If you're experiencing withdrawal or feel unable to make changes alone, seek professional support.
- If you plan on withdrawing from alcohol or benzodiazepines, medical supervision is **necessary.** Unmanaged withdrawal from those substances can be fatal.